

## THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1998-05-03

To the conference of the continental counselors

beloved friends,

it has been barely two years and four months since you came together

here at the outset of your current term of service. in our message to your

conference at that time, we described in detail not only the purpose and structure of the four year plan but the form in which it would have to

be pursued if it was to realize its ambitious aim. you were then given the

mandate to go forth and prepare the bahá'í world to take on the challenges

that lay ahead.

The extraordinary events of the convention we have all just witnessed bear

eloquent testimony to the ardor and effectiveness of your response. All of the institutions of the faith have most certainly played their parts in moving our

beloved cause a giant step forward in this brief period. The clarity and vigor

with which the National Spiritual Assemblies are addressing the tasks of the plan reflect that dramatic advance in maturity that the guardian encouraged

us to expect in these closing years of the century. we feel compelled, however,

to pay special tribute to the selfless, inspiring and intelligent contributions

which you have made to this collective enterprise. your work has brought

honor to your institution and immense joy to our hearts.

As a result of your unceasing activity during the months immediately

following the conference, the bahá'í world had been made ready, by the 264.1

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1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan

619time it received our rixván 1996 message, to enter into intensive detailed

planning. And once national plans were formulated your efforts did not

slacken; with equal vigor you and your auxiliaries galvanized the believers

into systematic action and helped them to remain focused on the central aim of the plan. we hope that you will convey to your Auxiliary board

members and their assistants our heartfelt gratitude.

The challenge which now faces the bahá'í world is to take advantage of

the momentum thus achieved. it has within its grasp the opportunity to

multiply its human resources on a scale far beyond anything heretofore attained. every measure must be taken to ensure that this possibility becomes

a reality. Training must be offered widely, to contingents of newly enrolled and veteran believers alike. it is also imperative that the energies being gen-

erated and the skills being developed through training institute programs be

channelled to serve directly the needs of the plan. in short—without any

delay—the work should move to the higher tempo that recent accomplish-

ments make possible.

your consultations this week need to be eminently practical. you come to

them with a wealth of experience that the bahá'í community has never be-

fore enjoyed. you are well aware of the diverse strengths of the communities

you serve and of the efficacy of the methods being employed in the field. The lessons of these past two years need to be examined and correlated,

and their implications for advancing the process of entry by troops must

be understood. in this context, you will also have to consider the increased

capacity of your own institution, the work of the Auxiliary board members,

and your interaction with them, with Spiritual Assemblies, and with the international Teaching center, whose concern it is to reinforce your efforts

with advice, perspectives and resources.

dear friends! you represent an army of able and highly motivated servants

of the cause throughout the world. yours is an institution which, in one

respect, has a particularly intimate relationship with the universal house of

justice; in another, it is able to exercise an influence that penetrates the very

grass roots of the community. its nature fits it, uniquely, to serve as a river of

encouragement, example and love whose waters can refresh and invigorate the spirit of every believer they touch.

we will follow your consultations this week with the heightened hope

and confidence which your impressive achievements to date have awakened. for your part, be sure of our ardent prayers that bahá'u'lláh will bless your

deliberations and confirm your efforts to help bring about the massive 265.4

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620increase in resources which the mission of our beloved cause so urgently  
requires.

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Training Institutes

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]